

A SCIENCE-BACKED GUIDE BY ASH | COUPLES EDUCATOR

The Pull-Away Antidote

What to do when they go cold, go quiet, or disappear, without losing yourself in the process.

ASH · COUPLES EDUCATOR · MFT STUDENT

How to Use This Guide

Read it in order the first time. Each section builds on the one before it. Start to finish, it takes about 20 minutes.

Bookmark Part Three so you can pull up the exact script you need in the moment.

Read the Science Appendix on the nights when your brain tells you that your reaction is irrational. It is not. The research will remind you of that.

“Your nervous system is not broken. It is doing exactly what it was built to do.”

This guide is rooted in the work of **Dr. Amir Levine and Rachel S. F. Heller** (*Attached*), **Dr. Stephen Porges** (Polyvagal Theory), and decades of research on why we love the way we love. The science is real. The scripts work because the psychology behind them works.

Take a breath. Let's go.

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to Your Secure Era

You didn't do anything wrong. Your body is just doing its job.

Take a deep breath. Drop your shoulders. Unclench your jaw.

You are exhausted. And you don't even know what you did wrong. Maybe they went cold overnight. Maybe they answered your real message with "yeah lol." Maybe they asked for space after what felt like a great week. Maybe it has been three days of silence and you have checked your phone so many times you lost count.

Here is what you need to hear right now: **You are not crazy. You are not too much. You did not do anything wrong.**

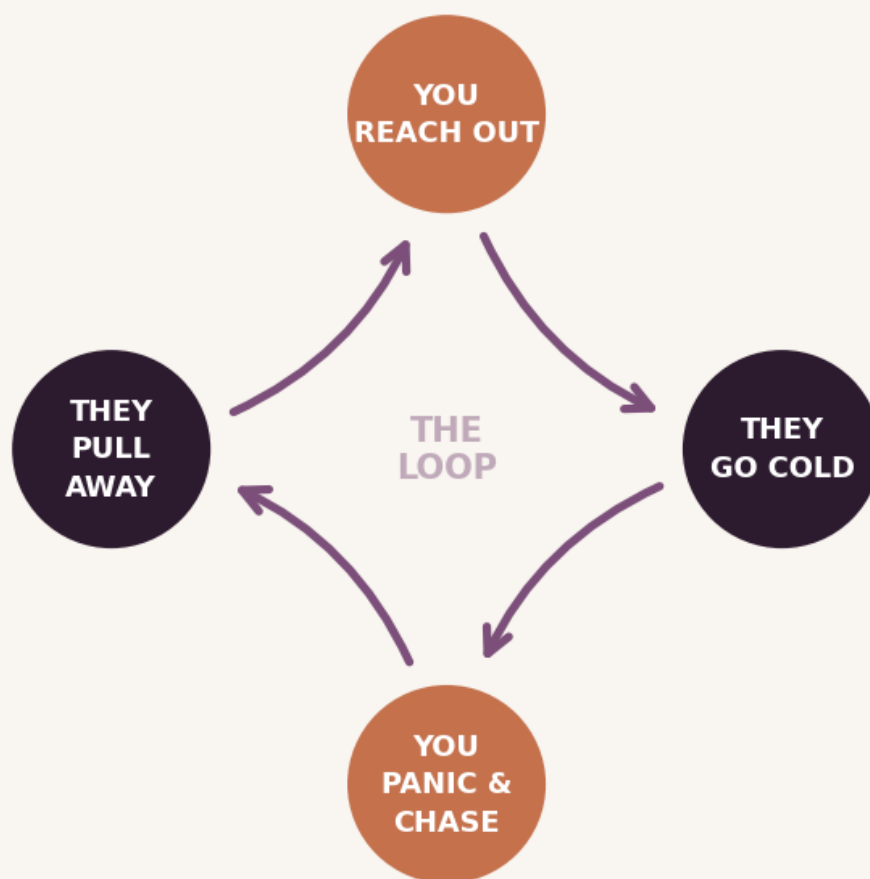
What you are feeling is a real, physical, body response, not a character flaw.

"The panic in your chest right now has a name. And it is not weakness."

Why your body goes into panic mode

Here is the science in plain terms: your brain is wired to treat losing someone close to you the same way it treats physical danger. When they pull away, the alarm center in your brain (called the amygdala) fires off like a smoke alarm. Your body floods with stress chemicals. Your heart races. Your stomach knots up. You feel an overwhelming urge to fix it *right now*.

That is not you being dramatic. Brain scans actually show that being rejected lights up the same parts of the brain as physical pain. The panic is real.



The Anxious-Avoidant Loop · your reach triggers their retreat, which triggers your panic

Why the cycle keeps repeating, your panic triggers their retreat, which triggers more panic.

What is happening on their end

Here is something important to understand. When an avoidant pulls away, it is *not* because they do not care. It is because getting close triggers *their* alarm system. To them, emotional closeness can feel overwhelming or even threatening. Their brain's response is to shut down and create distance, the same way yours responds by reaching closer.

Neither of you is doing this on purpose. You are both just responding to your own nervous systems.

But here is the trap: the more you reach, the more they pull away. The more they pull away, the more you panic and reach. Around and around it goes.

Starting today, you are breaking that loop.

PART ONE

The Do Not React List

Stop the panic moves that push them further away.

The Do Not React List

When you feel someone pulling away, your brain goes into emergency mode and pushes you to do things that feel urgent but actually make things worse. Scientists call these **Protest Behaviors**, but we can call them what they really are: panic moves.

Here is the hard truth: every panic move you make feels like closeness to you, but feels like pressure to them. And pressure makes an avoidant go even further. Stop doing these first.

Panic Moves vs. Secure Moves

PANIC MOVES (makes them go further)

- Sending 3+ texts in a row
- "Why are you ignoring me?"
- Long emotional paragraphs
- Checking their story / location
- Forcing "what are we?" talks
- Orbiting their social media

SECURE MOVES (lowers their guard)

- One message, then stop
- Giving space without chasing
- Saving hard talks for calm moments
- Muting them, focusing on yourself
- Timing big talks for a calm day
- Letting them make the next move

Panic moves push them further. Secure moves create space for them to come back.

STOP: DOUBLE AND TRIPLE TEXTING

The hot-and-cold pattern your partner has created is actually addictive, and not in a small way. It works the same way slot machines do. When reward is unpredictable, your brain gets obsessed with chasing it. Sending another text is just your brain begging for a hit of relief. Send one message. Then stop. Let it land.

STOP: THE LONG EMOTIONAL PARAGRAPH

It feels like if you just explain how much their silence hurts, they will finally get it. But here is the thing: an avoidant who is already shutting down cannot process a wall of emotion right now. It does not create empathy, it creates more overwhelm, which makes them pull away further. Save the deep conversation for a calm moment in person.

STOP: "WHAT ARE WE?" DURING A PULL-AWAY

You cannot get a real commitment from someone whose walls are up. When an avoidant is in shutdown mode, they are not emotionally available for a big relationship conversation. If you push for one now, you will not get what you need, and you will likely get the opposite. Wait for a calm window. Then have the talk.

STOP: CHECKING THEIR ACTIVITY

Watching their story views, checking their location, monitoring their last-seen, every single check sends another hit of stress chemicals through your body. You are basically re-alarming yourself every few minutes. Mute them if you have to. Your body needs a break from the information.

STOP: ACCEPTING BREADCRUMBS

A low-effort "i miss you" after three days of silence is a breadcrumb. Responding with full warmth and zero accountability teaches them that disappearing and reappearing costs them nothing. You can respond warmly, we will get to that in Part Three, but you do it with a boundary.

STOP: PUTTING YOUR WHOLE LIFE ON HOLD

The moment your entire world shrinks down to whether or not they replied, you have left yourself. That energy is something they can feel, even through a screen. Your life needs to keep moving. Not as a tactic. As a real commitment to not abandoning yourself while you wait.

"You are not weak for wanting to reach out. You are human. But you get to choose whether you act on it."

PART TWO

The Somatic Reset

You cannot send a calm text from a panicking body. Fix your body first.

The Somatic Reset

Before you send anything. Before you make any decisions. **You need to get your body out of panic mode first.**

Right now, your body is flooded with stress chemicals that literally shut down the thinking part of your brain. That means every decision you make right now will come from panic, not wisdom. The urgency you feel is a chemical spike, not intuition. Wait for it to pass.



You cannot respond from the left box. Get to the right box first.

The 2-to-4-Hour Rule

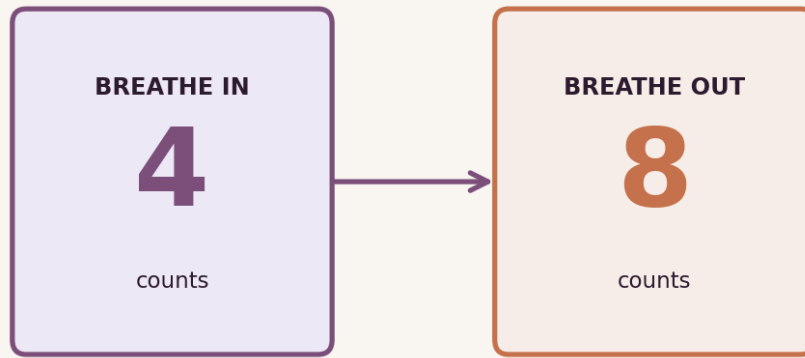
If they send a triggering message, ·I need space,· ·I've just been busy,· or even silence, you are not allowed to reply for at least 2 to 4 hours. If it is late at night, sleep on it.

The intense urgency you feel right now is a stress chemical spike. It will physically pass. Give your body time to settle before you touch your keyboard.

How to calm your body down fast

Your body has a built-in calm switch called the vagus nerve. Here is the fastest way to flip it:

THE BREATH RESET



Do this 5 times. The long exhale flips your body's calm switch.

The long exhale is what activates your body's calm-down switch.

Cold water on your face: Splashing cold water on your cheeks triggers a reflex that slows your heart rate almost immediately. It works fast.

The double inhale: Breathe in fully through your nose, then sneak in one more quick inhale to top off your lungs, then exhale slowly and completely. Stanford research shows this single breath pattern is one of the fastest ways to reduce acute stress.

Bring your energy back to yourself

Right now, every bit of your mental energy is pointed at them. You have completely left yourself to focus on someone who just pulled away.

Your job is to pull that energy back. Go to the gym. Call a friend and actually enjoy the conversation instead of using it to spiral. Work on something you care about. The goal is to make your life loud enough that their silence is just one thing happening, not everything.

“Your life does not stop for someone who isn’t showing up.”

PART THREE

The Scripts

Exactly what to say in every pull-away situation. Copy these. They work.

What to Actually Say

These scripts are designed to do one thing: show up warm and boundaried at the same time. Not cold. Not desperate. Secure.

People with secure attachment don't play games. But they also don't stay silent when something is not working. They say what they need clearly, without anger, and without begging. That is the energy in every script below.

Each scenario shows you the script AND a preview of what the conversation looks like so you can see exactly how it plays out.

Scenario A, Text

They say “I need space” or “I’m feeling overwhelmed.”

THE SECURE SCRIPT

“Got it. Take the time you need. I’ll be here when you’re ready.”

Why this works You gave them exactly what they asked for, but YOU framed it as your choice, not you waiting around. That one small shift changes the whole dynamic.

THEM

“hey i’ve just been feeling really overwhelmed and i think i need some space”

YOUR SECURE MOVE

“Got it. Take the time you need. I’ll be here when you’re ready.”

Scenario B, Text

They text back hours late with a one-word reply, “yeah lol” or just “hmm.”

THE SECURE SCRIPT (BEST OPTION)

No reply.

Why this works: Silence is a complete answer. You matched their energy without chasing. One clear message: you don't chase. Your life is moving. You are not sitting by your phone waiting.

THE SECURE SCRIPT (IF YOU MUST REPLY)

"Haha okay. Hope your day's good!"

Why this works: Short, warm, and done. You are not dependent on their response to feel okay. Your life is full with or without them.

THEM

"yeah lol"

YOUR SECURE MOVE

"Haha okay. Hope your day's good!"

Scenario C, Text

After days of silence, they text "Hey."

THE SECURE SCRIPT

·Hey! Been a pretty full week over here, how are you?·

Why this works: Warm, but not dropping everything. You are not punishing them. You are also not acting like nothing happened. You're just... fine. Living your life. That is the most attractive version of yourself.

THEM

"Hey"

YOUR SECURE MOVE

·Hey! Been a pretty full week over here ,
how are you?"

Scenario D, Text

They text “I miss you” with no explanation after going cold.

THE SECURE SCRIPT

“Miss you too. Want to actually catch up? I’m free later this week.”

Why this works: “I miss you” with no follow-through is a breadcrumb. This response acknowledges the feeling without rewarding the disappearing act. You are nudging toward a real connection instead of letting them collect your warmth and go cold again.

THEM

“i miss you”

YOUR SECURE MOVE

“Miss you too. Want to actually catch up?
I’m free later this week.”

Scenario E, Text

They cancel plans last minute with a vague excuse.

THE SECURE SCRIPT

“No worries! Gonna keep my plans. Let me know when you can actually commit to a time.”

Why this works: You are not punishing them. But you are not pretending last-minute canceling is fine. “When you can actually commit” names the pattern without a lecture. That is the secure move.

THEM

“hey something came up, can we
raincheck?”

YOUR SECURE MOVE

“No worries! Gonna keep my plans. Let me
know when you can actually commit to a
time.”

Scenario F, Text

They say “I care about you but I don’t know what I want right now.”

THE SECURE SCRIPT

“Thanks for being honest. I need to be with someone who actually knows they want to be here. Take the time to figure it out, I’ll keep moving in the meantime.”

Why this works: “I don’t know what I want” is not a commitment. This is not an ultimatum. It is just the truth: you need clarity to feel safe, and you are not going to put your life on pause while they figure it out.

THEM

“i care about you but i’m just not sure what i want right now”

YOUR SECURE MOVE

“Thanks for being honest. I need someone who knows they want to be here. Take the time, I’ll keep moving.”

Scenario G, Text

They are watching your stories and liking old posts but not texting.

THE SECURE SCRIPT

No reply.

Why this works: Watching without reaching out is how an avoidant stays connected without being vulnerable. If you text first, you take all the pressure off them. Hold your ground. They know how to reach out.

Scenario H, Text

They were good for a few weeks, then went cold again. The cycle repeated.

THE SECURE SCRIPT

“Hey, things have felt a bit off lately and I just wanted to name it. Not trying to start anything. Just noticed. I’m here.”

Why this works You name the shift calmly, no accusation, no panic. You are not chasing. You are not pretending nothing happened. You leave the door open and step back. That is the secure move.

THEM

“[3 days of one-word replies after a good stretch]”

YOUR SECURE MOVE

·Hey, things have felt a bit off lately and I just wanted to name it. Not trying to start anything. Just noticed. I’m here.”

Scenario I, Text

They say all the right things, but nothing actually changes.

THE SECURE SCRIPT (say this to yourself)

“Words are nice. But I’m watching what they actually do. That’s my real answer.”

Why this works This one is not for them, it is for you. A reminder that what they say during a reconnection is the starting line, not the finish line. Secure people watch patterns over time. Not one good night.

In-Person Scenarios

Not every hard moment happens over text. Sometimes they go cold while you’re literally sitting across from them. Here is what to do when the pull-away happens face to face.

Scenario J, In Person

They show up after being cold and act like nothing happened.

THE SECURE MOVE

SAY ·Hey, it’s good to see you. I did notice things felt a little off lately, just wanted to say that out loud.”

YOUR ENERGY: Calm. No edge in your voice. You say it once and then let it breathe. You are not starting a fight. You are just being honest.

NOT THIS: *“Pretending everything is fine and stuffing it down. That builds resentment.”*

Scenario K, In Person

Mid-date, they go quiet and distant out of nowhere.

THE SECURE MOVE

SAY: “You seem a little far away right now. Everything okay?”

YOUR ENERGY: Gentle curiosity, not accusation. You check in once. If they say “I’m fine,” you trust it and keep enjoying your night. You do not chase the mood.

NOT THIS: *“‘Are you mad at me? Did I do something? Why are you being like this?’ That chasing energy hands them all the power.”*

Scenario L, In Person

Face to face, they say “I don’t know if I’m ready for something serious.”

THE SECURE MOVE

SAY · I appreciate you telling me. I’m not going to push. But I also need to be honest, I’m looking for something real. So if that’s not where you are, I get it. I just need to know.”

YOUR ENERGY: No tears, no begging, no convincing them. Steady eye contact. You mean it. You are giving them an easy out AND holding your standard at the same time.

NOT THIS: *“‘Okay, I’m fine with whatever, I can wait, we can just see what happens.’ That makes you the option, not the priority.”*

Scenario M, In Person

During a conflict, they shut down and go completely silent.

THE SECURE MOVE

SAY ·I can see this is hard. I·m not going anywhere. Take a few minutes if you need it, but I do want us to come back to this.”

YOUR ENERGY: You give them space without abandoning the conversation. You stay regulated. That is the most powerful thing you can do when someone shuts down, stay calm and stay present.

NOT THIS: *“Raising your voice, following them around the room, or sending a wall of texts after they leave. That makes the shutdown worse.”*

PART FOUR

The Standard Setter

Them coming back is a starting point. Not a finish line.

The Standard Setter

Here is the part that nobody talks about enough. Using these scripts and keeping your cool will often make them come back. The calm, unbothered, not-chasing energy actually lowers an avoidant's defenses. It works.

But them coming back is not the goal. It is information.

When they come back, pay attention. How long did it take? Did they acknowledge what happened or just act like nothing did? Did they come back with words or with real follow-through? What they do when they re-enter tells you almost everything.

When They Come Back: What To Do



What they say is a starting point. What they consistently DO is the answer.

A simple decision map for when they come back.

A simple decision map for when they come back.

How to have the standard setter conversation

Once things have calmed down and you are reconnected, in person or on a call, not over text , have this conversation:

THE STANDARD SCRIPT

“I genuinely like spending time with you, and I want to see where this goes. But I need consistency to feel safe. The hot and cold is hard on me. I’m not asking for perfection , just honesty and follow-through. Is that something you can do right now?”

Why this works: You are naming a need without attacking them. You are asking about their capacity with real curiosity, not a threat. And you are giving them a chance to be honest. If they say yes, watch their actions. If they say no, or if they repeat the pattern, you have your answer.

If they keep pulling away

That is your answer. Not a maybe. Not “not yet.” An answer.

A person with secure attachment does not stay in something that keeps their nervous system in permanent emergency mode. You were not built for a constant loop of chase and pull-away. You deserve something consistent.

“You do not have to shrink yourself or wait around for someone to realize your worth.”

If they cannot show up with basic consistency, choosing yourself is not giving up. It is the most secure, self-respecting thing you can do.

APPENDIX

The Science Behind the Script

Because “too needy” was never a diagnosis. It was a misread of your nervous system.

The Science Behind the Script

Every concept in this guide comes from real research. If you have ever been told you are ‘too much’, here is what the science actually says about what is happening inside you.

1. ATTACHMENT THEORY · Why We Love the Way We Love

The core ideas in this guide, the anxious-avoidant cycle, the urge to chase, the shutdown response, come from the landmark book *Attached* by Dr. Amir Levine and Rachel S. F. Heller. Their work built on decades of research by Drs. John Bowlby and Mary Ainsworth. About 20% of adults have an anxious attachment style and 25% have an avoidant style. These two types are drawn to each other more than any other pairing. The cycle you are in is well-documented and very common.

2. POLYVAGAL THEORY · Your Body’s Calm Switch

The breathing and body techniques in Part Two come from Polyvagal Theory, developed by Dr. Stephen Porges. Your vagus nerve acts like a brake pedal for your stress response. When you extend your exhale, breathing out longer than you breathe in, it directly activates that brake pedal and moves your body from panic mode into calm mode. A 2023 Stanford study by Balban et al. found that the double-inhale breath pattern is one of the most effective real-time stress reducers ever tested.

3. BRAIN SCANS · Rejection Hurts Like Physical Pain

Dr. Naomi Eisenberger at UCLA used brain imaging to show that social rejection activates the same exact areas of the brain as physical pain. When your person goes cold, your brain’s alarm center (the amygdala) reads it as a threat to your survival and floods your body with stress chemicals. The chest tightness, the stomach knot, the racing heart, all of it is your body responding to a real threat signal. You are not being dramatic.

4. INTERMITTENT REINFORCEMENT · Why You Can’t Stop Thinking About Them

Behaviorist B. F. Skinner found that when rewards are unpredictable, the drive to chase them gets stronger, not weaker. This is the exact mechanism behind slot machine addiction. When your partner is warm sometimes and cold other times, your brain locks into a loop of chasing the next warm moment. You are not weak for being stuck in this pattern. You are experiencing a real neurological loop that scientists can measure in a lab.

5. EARNED SECURE ATTACHMENT · You Can Change

Attachment styles are formed in childhood, but they are not permanent. Research shows that adults can build what scientists call Earned Secure Attachment, meaning you can move toward security through self-awareness, therapy, and healthier relationships, regardless of where you started. Dr. Mary Main found that what matters is not what happened to you in childhood but how clearly you can understand and talk about it. The work you are doing right now counts.

Books worth reading

Attached, Amir Levine, M.D. and Rachel S. F. Heller, M.A. (start here)

The Polyvagal Theory, Stephen W. Porges, Ph.D.

Hold Me Tight, Dr. Sue Johnson

Wired for Love, Stan Tatkin, Psy.D.

You Did Not Come This Far to Settle for Inconsistency.

You came into this guide with a knot in your stomach. I hope you are leaving with something steadier.

You now know why your body reacts the way it does. You know how to stop the behaviors that make things worse. You know how to calm yourself down. And you know what to say in every scenario.

More than any of that: you are not too much. You are not broken. You are someone whose nervous system responds to connection the way it was built to, and who now has the tools to respond from a place of security instead of panic.

You deserve someone who is consistent. Someone who shows up. Someone who does not make you wonder.

With love and attachment science,

Ash | Couples Educator